

Class 12

Labor Markets and Worker Power

Part III — Mobilizing People and Expanding Opportunity

Union membership and top-income shares

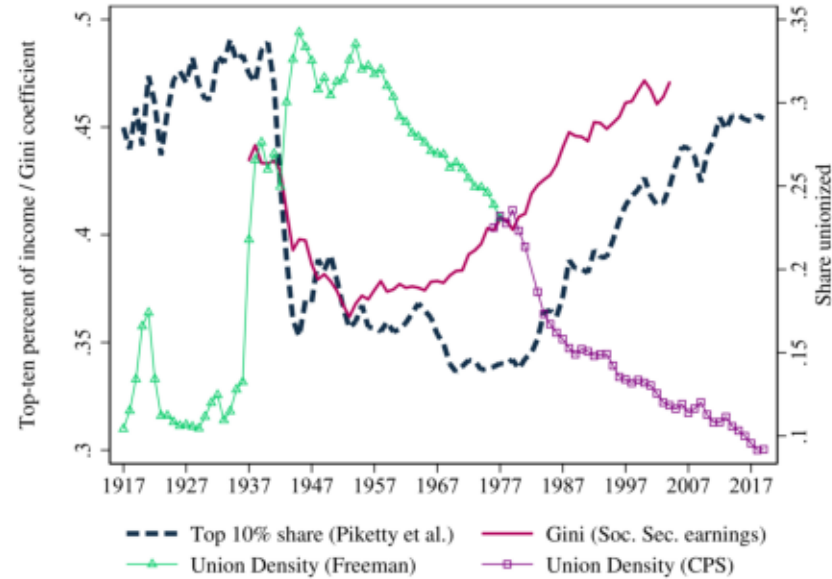
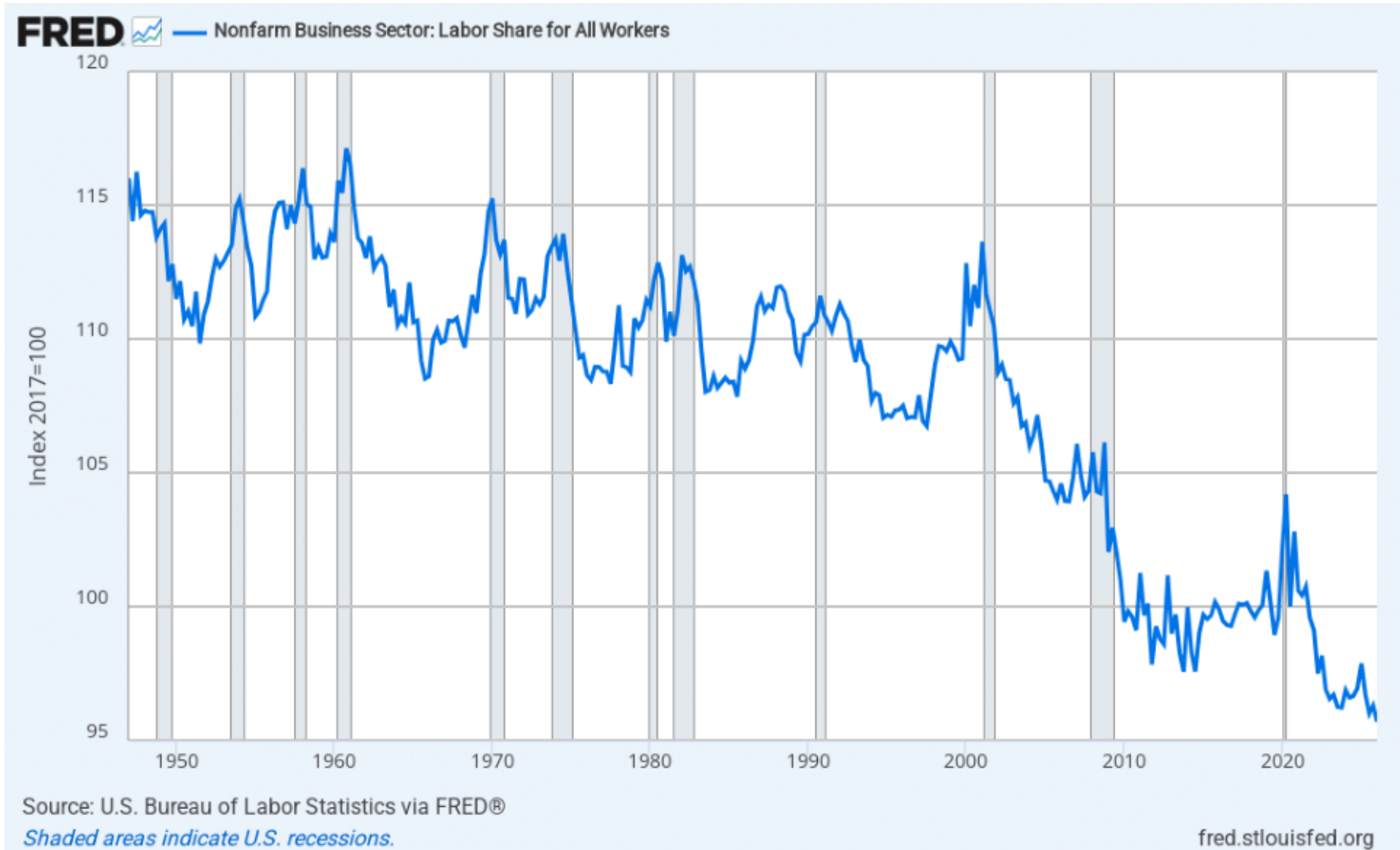


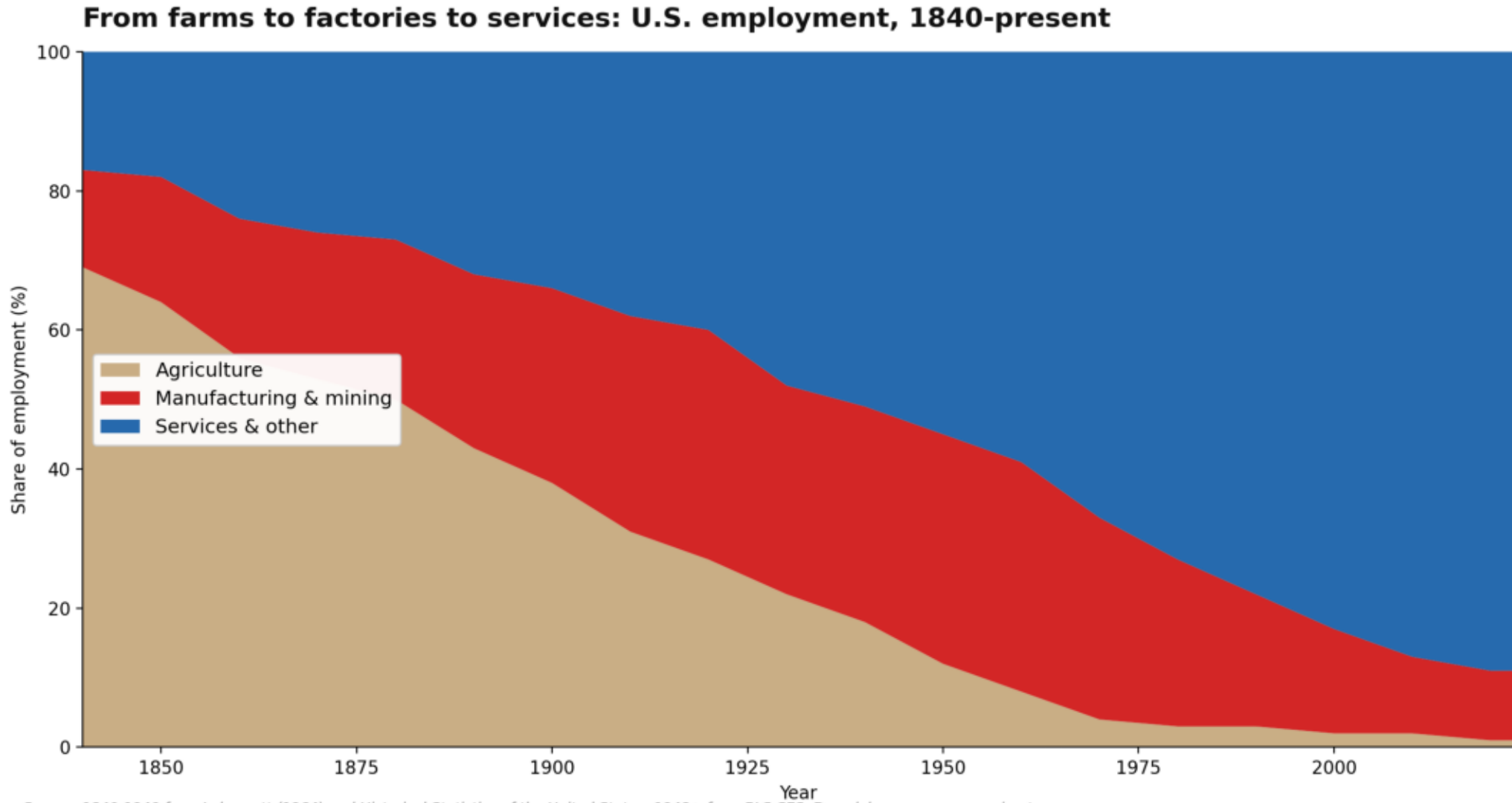
FIGURE I: UNION DENSITY AND INEQUALITY MEASURES, 1917-2019

Data sources: Top share individual income inequality from Piketty, Saez, and Zucman (2018). Union density is number of unionized workers as a share of non-agricultural workforce from Historical Statistics of the United States, together with individual union density as a share of employed civilian workers ages 16 to 65 from the Current Population Survey. We discuss these data sources in detail in Section II.B and Appendix E.

The U.S. labor share of national income



Where Americans work: sectoral employment shares

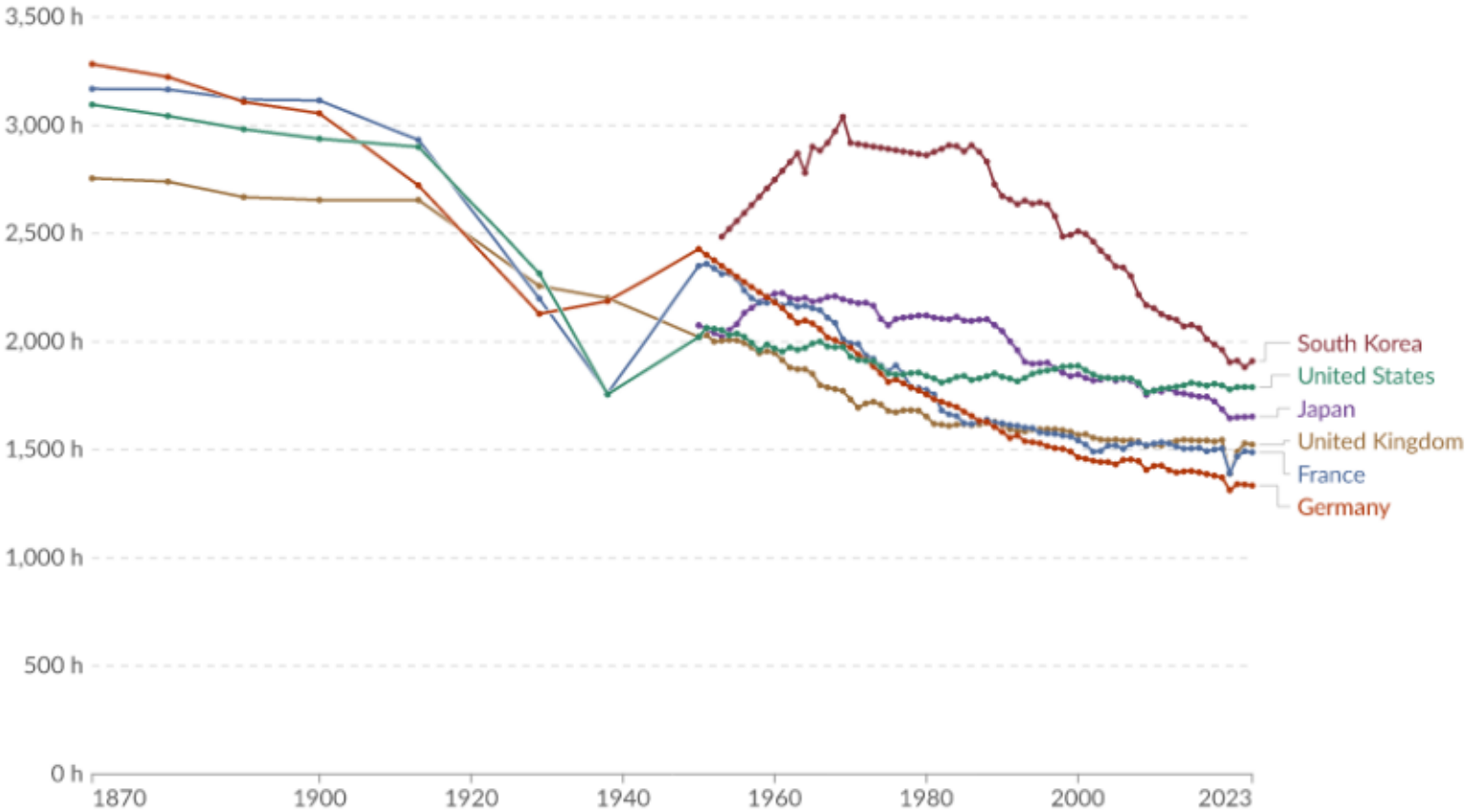


Annual hours worked per worker, U.S. vs. Europe

Annual working hours per worker



Before 1950, the data comes only from full-time production workers (non-agricultural activities). Starting in 1950, estimates cover total hours worked in the economy as measured primarily from national accounts data.



Data source: Feenstra et al. - Penn World Table (2025); Huberman and Minns (2005)

OurWorldinData.org/working-hours | CC BY